

that he was hospitalised. His mother visited him every morning before going to work. "That is the only reason I feel bad. My parents had to go through the trauma in their old age because of me," he says. The positive that has emerged out of the terrible ordeal is that Ransley has begun adoring his family more, despite the fact that his parents keep blaming him for going to Leopold for a mug of beer. "If it would have been anyone else, we would have been worried. But Ransley has handled everything with a smile," says his father. Though Ransley continues to be a brat in front of his parents, he is aware of their concern about his marital prospects due to the injury. "But I feel that it will happen when it has to happen. I don't worry about it," he says.

Today, Ransley's attitude towards the physically disabled has undergone a transformation. After the unwelcome stares he received while walking, he has stopped pitying the disabled. "I think they can take care of themselves and don't need sympathy." What he misses is an early morning jog, which used to be a ritual for him. He misses sharing the bench with his friends at the Welinkar College, where he is pursuing a management degree, as he hasn't been able to attend classes. Nevertheless, he has classmates who come home to teach him. Ransley, in fact, jokes about his enjoying the status of a "pseudo-celebrity". He has tried to move on but the only thing that pulls him back to the dreadful day is the sound of footsteps and firecrackers. It might take a few more years for him to walk without support, but his life is already sailing smoothly. *by Mitali Patel*

KEEPING THE DREAM ALIVE

KALPANA SHAH, 51

WHAT HAPPENED: Lost her husband, Pankaj, at the Oberoi

Some of the buildings that stand tall in Mumbai remind Kalpana Shah of the strength and power her husband Pankaj personified. He was the chairman of Satellite Developers Group that has built some notable buildings in the city like the Sarjan Plaza near Atria Mall and The View that houses the Tao Art Gallery in Worli. His most ambitious building, a magnificent 40-storeyed apartment block at Napean Sea Road, was under construction when he fell to the terrorists' bullets on the night of 26/11. He had gone to Kandahar, a restaurant at the Oberoi in Mumbai for dinner with friends—only four of the 17 in the group survived.

Kalpana remembers her husband as an extremely talented and dynamic individual, not only as a professional but even as a friend, father and husband. "After his death there's been a lacuna which can never be filled," she says. Pankaj always made sure that his wife and two children, son Sarjan, 20 and daughter

“I wouldn't want any other woman to go through my ordeal. I pray for the riddance of terrorism.”

KALPANA SHAH

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